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PODCAST

« We might not have a leg or a hand, but we're mentally very strong and capable of doing things able-bodied people can't »

BHAVINA PATEL

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It's been four years since Bhavina Patel made history in Tokyo, winning India's first-ever Paralympic medal in table tennis — a silver.

Since then, the Gujarat paddler has continued her rise, most recently clinching consecutive singles gold medals at international events in Chinese Taipei. In the second of those, she defeated South Korea's Moon Sung-hye, a five-time Paralympic medallist, in the final.

With more major tournaments on the horizon, Bhavina remains focused on sharpening her skills. But she feels the current para table tennis scene in India leaves much to be desired. In a conversation with *Sportstar*, the 38-year-old opened up about accessibility issues, her hope for a para version of the Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) league, and her coaching aspirations for the future.

In what ways have things changed for you since that silver medal in 2021 at the Tokyo Paralympics?

I've seen how people's perceptions change after you win a major medal for your country. Distant relatives have suddenly remembered me. I've also stopped shying away from spending on equipment. We've got more social media coverage now. Even within my family, they trust me more.

Do you think that all these changes would have happened if you hadn't won the medal?

No, I don't think so. Before the medal, no one knew who Bhavina Patel was. People used to say things like "She's wasting her father's money" and "What's the point of doing all this?". But I had a burning desire to do something for the country.

What do you think about para athletes being constantly viewed from the lens of inspiration?

As long as people aren't aware of the level at which we play, the medals we've won, and how we've performed at the Paralympics, they'll think of us as *becharas* (helpless). Once they know, they salute.

They can never imagine wheelchair-bound people as athletes. Those who don't have someone like that in their family can never understand what disability is. Awareness campaigns should be run in the country, but I don't think we can change everyone's mindset — and that's okay. We don't want people's sympathy.

We might not have a leg or a hand, but we're mentally very strong and capable of doing things able-bodied people can't. Whenever we go abroad, there's a designated